

An Argument, Not a Topic

Lesson 1 — Introduction to Paper 3: command terms and essay structure

What you will know and be able to do

- 1 Explain how Paper 3 differs fundamentally from Paper 1 and Paper 2
- 2 Identify the key command term in a Paper 3 question and what it demands
- 3 Explain why every Paper 3 question now presents a claim you must evaluate, not an open topic
- 4 Preview our two regional in-depth topics and why they were chosen together

From sources, to arguments

Paper 1 tested how you use unfamiliar sources. Paper 2 tested how you write a focused essay using a concept and one thematic study. Paper 3 tests something else again: how deeply you understand one region's history, and how well you can construct and defend a historical argument about it — in conversation with what historians themselves have argued.

The exam's structure

FORMAT

- HL only — not taken by SL students
- 2 hours, 30 marks, 35% of the final HL grade
- One region, two regional in-depth topics
- Two essays, one from each topic — neither can be skipped

WHAT'S TESTED

- In-depth factual knowledge of the chosen region
- Constructing a structured, evidenced argument
- Engaging with historians' interpretations and debates
- Precise, disciplined response to the exact question asked

Every question now hands you a claim

The previous syllabus mixed open essay prompts (“Examine the causes of X”) with argument-evaluation prompts (“‘X was the main cause.’ To what extent do you agree?”). The new syllabus has standardised this: every single Paper 3 question now presents a specific historical claim that you must evaluate — agree, disagree, or qualify, with evidence.

This matters enormously for how you plan: your very first job is to decide what you actually think of the claim, before you start writing.

A typical Paper 3 question

*“Economic factors were the primary force behind the rise of Arab nationalism after 1945.”
To what extent do you agree with this claim?*

A representative Paper 3 style question, modelled on the format confirmed for the new syllabus.

You are the judge, not just the witness

Notice what this question is not asking: it is not simply asking you to describe Arab nationalism's rise. It is asking you to weigh economic factors against political, ideological, and other causes, and reach your own reasoned verdict — supported by specific evidence, and aware of how historians themselves have disagreed about the answer.

The words that decide your entire answer

Evaluate / To what extent

Weigh a specific claim against evidence and alternative explanations, and reach a reasoned judgement.

Discuss

Offer a balanced, considered review of an issue, including different interpretations, before concluding.

Examine

Consider an argument or concept in a way that uncovers the assumptions and inter-relationships of the issue.

Compare and contrast

Identify both similarities and differences between two cases — never only one or the other.

Answering the topic instead of the question

Every year, strong students lose marks by writing everything they know about a topic instead of answering the specific claim asked. If a question asks you to weigh economic causes against other causes, and you only describe economic causes without weighing anything, you have written a strong essay on the wrong question.

The four specified concepts, doing a new job

Cause and consequence, continuity and change, perspectives, and significance are still the four concepts underneath everything — but here they shape how you build an argument, not how you read a source. “To what extent” questions are almost always, underneath, asking you to weigh cause and consequence, or to judge significance.

You are expected to know what historians argue, not just what happened

A strong Paper 3 answer refers to real historical debates — naming specific historians and summarising, briefly and accurately, where they disagree and why. This is not decoration: examiners explicitly reward awareness and evaluation of historical interpretations as a distinct skill.

Africa and the Middle East

From four possible regions — Africa and the Middle East, the Americas, Asia and Oceania, and Europe — we have chosen Africa and the Middle East. It connects directly to Kenya from Paper 1, and it sits at the centre of the international, Gulf-facing career path this course also serves.

The Middle East, and African independence movements

Topic one: revolution, reform, and foreign relations in the Middle East, circa 1945–2020 — Arab nationalism, the Arab-Israeli conflict, the Iranian Revolution, and the region's shifting relationship with foreign powers. Topic two: independence movements in Algeria, Angola, Ghana, Guinea, Namibia, and Tanganyika, circa 1900–2000 — six very different paths out of colonial rule on the same continent.

Two regions, one recurring question

Both topics ask, in different settings, how new political orders get built once old ones are forced out — the exact question this entire course, across Paper 1's Haiti and Kenya, has already been asking. Paper 3 lets us go far deeper into a narrower set of cases.

Plan before you write, every single time

Read the question twice. Identify and underline the command term and the specific claim. Decide, before writing a single sentence of your answer, roughly where you stand — agree, disagree, or a qualified middle position — and sketch which evidence supports that view. This habit, more than any other, separates strong Paper 3 answers from weak ones.

Deconstructing a question

For each question below, identify the command term, the specific claim being made, and what a balanced answer would need to weigh.

- 'Nasser's leadership was the single most important factor in the rise of Pan-Arabism.' To what extent do you agree?
- Compare and contrast the roles of external powers in the independence movements of Algeria and Ghana.
- Examine the reasons for, and consequences of, the 1979 Iranian Revolution.

Working through the first one together

“To what extent” signals an argument-evaluation question. The specific claim is that Nasser's leadership, specifically, was the single most important cause — not merely a cause. A balanced answer must weigh Nasser's personal role against other forces: the legacy of colonialism, the 1956 Suez Crisis, Cold War rivalry, and broader currents of Arab nationalism that predated him.

Key terms from today

Regional in-depth topic

One of two chosen subtopics, from twelve, within a selected HL region.

Argument-evaluation question

A question presenting a claim you must agree with, disagree with, or qualify.

Command term

The specific instruction word in a question that dictates the required response.

Historiography

The study of how historians have interpreted and argued about the past.

How this course is built

This course draws on Mike Wells' Cambridge Paper 3 series for structure and technique, on Mimmack, Price and Senés' coverage of the Arab-Israeli conflict for grounded 1945–79 content, and on James Gelvin's history of the modern Middle East for broader context — supplemented by dedicated research for the Middle East since 2008 and for each African independence movement.

What to remember

Paper 3 tests in-depth knowledge, argument construction, and engagement with historiography — not source analysis. Every question now presents a specific claim to evaluate, and the command term tells you exactly what kind of judgement is required. Plan your position before you write.

Lesson 2 — Building a Paper 3 essay

Next lesson: turning a deconstructed question and a rough position into an actual, structured essay — introduction, paragraphing, and a real conclusion.